

Decisive clash at Five Forks

Grant at once determined to take advantage of this reverse. On March 29, he sent an infantry corps accompanied by General Philip Sheridan's cavalry, newly arrived from the victorious Union campaign in the Shenandoah Valley, to probe the western end of Lee's lines. Lee took vigorous measures to counter the move, and there was hard fighting on March 30, with neither side managing to achieve an advantage. The next day, Philip Sheridan's horsemen confronted General George E. Pickett's division at a crossroads known as Five Forks, 20 miles (32km) southwest of Petersburg.

Sheridan dispatched the Fifth Corps of the Army of the Potomac under Major General Gouverneur K. Warren with orders to attack the Confederate left flank. Despite confusion in the plan's execution, the pincer attack worked. By 7 p.m., Pickett's force had collapsed, with half the men surrendering and the rest taking flight. The Union breakthrough had finally been achieved.

The defeat at Five Forks, sometimes called the "Waterloo of the Confederacy," threatened Lee's last remaining lines of communication to the west and south and his position was untenable. The next morning, April 2, he sent word to Jefferson Davis that Petersburg would fall and that when it did, Richmond itself would have to be abandoned.

As it happened, the message had barely reached the Southern president, who was attending a Sunday-morning church service at the time, when Grant's men launched an all-out attack along Lee's lines at Petersburg. The Confederates resisted, but only as a holding action designed to give the army time to withdraw in some semblance of order from the beleaguered city. By the following morning, Petersburg was in Union hands.